This Puny World

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/35337790.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Categories:
Other, F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Finn | Adora/Catra Child (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Original Characters

Additional Tags:
Dark, Introspection, Psychological Trauma, Mortality, Self-Acceptance, Catra (She-Ra) Needs a Hug, POV Catra (She-Ra), Catra Needs Therapy (She-Ra), Poor Catra (She-Ra), Mindfuck, Author Is Sleep Deprived, Slow Build, Freeform, POV First Person, Flashbacks, Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner's A+ Parenting, Abusive Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Death, Past Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Childhood Friends, Loss of Innocence, Warm and Fuzzy Feelings, Love, Family, Forests, Boats and Ships, Running Away, Self-Discovery, World Travel, Environmentalism, Whispering Woods (She-Ra), Salineas (She-Ra), Bright Moon (She-Ra), Poetry, Prose Poem, Rhyming, Fire, Wilderness

Language:
English

Series:
Part 1 of Tales from the Puny World

Stats:
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by Nexus_Nexus

Summary

Catra embarks on a journey out to a sea full of strange animals and familiar horrors. It's her way of escaping the puny world she once sunk down into.

A Bird Flew Overhead (intro)

Get Up. You're embarrassing.

That's okay, because the floor is warmer than I. Maybe I am just cold. Maybe it's the other way around.

The floor is warm, I am cold, I cannot tell the difference. Get up, she tells me once again, but still, I didn't listen.

A bird flew over my head the other day, shockingly, since there have been no birds above these skies for as long as I can remember. I thought I had imagined it but then it looked at me and I suddenly knew exactly what it was doing there. I watched as the solitary mother scraped the skyline with her terrified, terrifying eyes and her beak that could crush me at a moment's notice. I noticed a faint bubbling, the little bird in my stomach was trying to escape and see its mother, but I managed to keep it subdued in its own pool of acid where it lays drenched and burning still. I had only seen this bird once before, decades ago. I was on the highest point of the entire universe back then, far away from where it all was. I wasn't fit for the lowest crevices in this puny world of mine, so I stayed out of them by staying up there. I watch, transfixed, as the bird far above me slowly shrinks until it becomes a fly, then a gnat, then dust, then gone. Her terrified, terrifying eyes, which had not budged an inch, began to make me feel like a bird myself. As I sit on top of this puny world of mine, I wonder whether I was born like this on purpose, or if I was destined to end up flying the skies like that gracious creature. My eyes were not terrifying enough yet. The bird in my throat squawked, and so I pushed it back down to my stomach and I sat there and I cried. The sea flowed from my terrifying, not-terrified-enough eyes and there were no more fish left in it because the ones with wings flew away and I don't have any wings anymore. All I can do is sit here and let the ocean flow. The floor is warm. I looked up to see if the terrified, terrifying eyes would look back at me one more time, but I only saw the three kind, coldhearted

ones that often lit up the dead night sky. I hate the moons, but I loved her. The bird in my eyeballs plunged back into the depths of the sea and I'm sitting here with no fish and eyes that are terrifying but not terrified enough. Not yet. They are terrified now, but they haven't always been. Not then. Now, I can see that she looks at me with more fear than I look at myself. The wrong fish sat in the wrong desert. I know she won't kill me and I know it won't matter. Her eyes are terrifying and terrified and coldhearted but not kind. Not like hers. When I look at the bird mother's eyes, all I see are the eyes of the fish that swam up the waterfall and out of my life. The reason that I was sitting at the top of this puny world and crying and not getting up. If I got up I would have to go further down into the den and further away from the kind eyes of the sky that were the same kind eyes she looked at me with before I didn't swim up the waterfall with them. Never have I felt more alone than now, surrounded by the flocks of birds and insects and fish that swallow bits of my brain each time they surge into the skies. I know that I could have left the sea with her but I don't have wings. She was given wings even though we were both chopped up in the same slaughterhouse by the same butcher at the same time. The issue is that the butcher was thorough in slicing me up, but was sloppy with her, so she kept her wings that she was born with while mine were chopped up, sold, marinated, cooked, eaten, devoured. She had a beak that could crush me at a moment's notice but soon it became a fly, then a gnat, then dust, then gone. At this time I'm not sure which place is the memory, the palace or the ocean. The kind eyes in the sky or the coldhearted eyes of the woman standing in front of me that won't kill me and I know it won't matter. Nothing makes any sense anymore but yet I am satisfied with the little sense I have. At a true rock bottom there is relaxation because you know that nothing matters, because you can lie to rest while the current passes you by and nothing will happen. And after everything, our childhoods, our fights, our wars, our love, our moon, our falling apart, and then me. Alone. After all of that, there is nothing left to be scared of. Those terrified, terrifying eyes have already turned to flies, then dust, then gone, and I wonder if I should follow suit.

"You've lost"

Get up.

No. She doesn't care about that anymore.

The floor is boiling, I am warm. The woman that stands in front of me is cold and I want her gone but for now she cools me down. She is dust too, just like me, and even though I hate her, she is comforting. She just doesn't know it, but that's all I know now.

The floor is boiling. I am warm. The woman is cold. We are both dust.

"Looks like we're both alone- Sparkles"

Terrified, Terrifying Eyes

As the trees tore past my face, all I could think about was staying on my feet and staying alive. I didn't care about what had just happened or what would happen in only a matter of hours, as the adrenaline dug a hole through my muscles and made my skeleton shake in its thin cocoon of meat. I thought they were hungry. If I hadn't run, if I had not been able to quell the bird that migrated down to my knees and wanted to stay there forever, maybe my fate would have been better. Maybe I would have lived, or maybe they would have killed me on the spot like they did the rest. In that one moment, all I could see were three things.

My home (burnt). My mother (burning). The fire (burning).

Then, they appeared through the fire (burning) with their large, strange metal animals that took my home (burned) and my mother (burning). The little bird cooed a calm, soft sound that buckled the bolts in my head, urging me to lie down and rest. My eyes were resting too, but the eyelids would not budge. They stood upright and fed me the paintings, with their intricate brush marks, of everything that I had seen before while my eyes were still standing too.

My home (gone). My mother (burning). The fire (burning). The soldiers in dark grey uniforms with their eyes covered (coming closer).

It was all so freakish, the viscera of combat, the ruthlessness of a military that thinks it's doing the world a service, the shooting and killing of thousands upon thousands of little birds all drenched in stomach acid and cooing calmly to lie down and rest. The soldiers in their dark grey uniforms (coming closer) seemed to grow darker until they were black, just like the surrounding forest: the thick canopy of trees and vines that wrapped around my little crevice, the creek that dragged itself painfully around houses and farms and under small bridges (burning), the bones covered or uncovered by thin cocoons of meat (burning, burnt), the small

houses and large barns made of brown wood and gray stone that stood taller than the bodies inhabiting them (burning, burnt), the large strange metal animals that encapsulated the painting currently being fed to my terrified, terrifying eyes, every individual stroke and hair of the paintbrush in plain sight. That was, until, the entire painting slowly grew darker until I could no longer see anything anymore.

My home (gone). My mother (gone). The fire (gone). The soldiers in dark grey uniforms with their eyes covered (gone). The water (everywhere).

The smell of the sea, putrid and full of death, rammed through my nostrils and into the deepest recesses of my memories, never leaving that spot. My mother (gone) was no longer in sight and the soldiers in darker grey uniforms and their eyes wide open (farther away) were terrified. I wanted to see the scene behind me, but the artist hadn't painted it yet. The water rose once again and the town (gone) became dark once again, but the large strange metal animals were less terrified than the soldiers in dark grey uniforms with their eyes facing behind me (far away). The animals shrieked and the painting turned blindingly bright, as if the sun appeared down on the ground in front of the town (gone). The bird in my knees raised its head and looked at me, no longer cooing its relaxing song or telling me to lie down and rest. It sat in the puddle of acid once again, still, quiet, and alert. The creek dragged itself painfully around my thin cocoon of meat, bringing water to every little crevice in my body and feeding the little bird inside my stomach. My knees creaked and groaned and screamed as they unlocked and bent my body to get ready to run. My terrified, terrifying eyes darted from the painting over to the story unfolding behind me: the water that blocked out the sun was falling and so was the fish with wings that was controlling it. They sprinted, without moving, towards the bottom of the lake and I sprinted, while moving, away from my home (gone) and my mother (gone). My footsteps multiplied and soon all I heard was the sound of feet, pummeling the floor of the forest with the thick canopy of trees and vines that wrapped around my little crevice and the creek that smoothly curled its tongue through the foliage

and into the lake. I must have been running for some time or else the lake would not have caught up with me, just like the soldiers in grey uniforms with their eyes covered (here) had. They were yelling, the little birds in their knees long dead, and a few were growing larger by the second. One soldier drew a long stick, not the kind I used to burn for kindling, but one that was already burning with an artificial light, ready to hurt me. I would either be hurt or killed, so I took my claws and I scraped a gash in my puny world so deep that it emerged from the painting in front of me, through my terrified, terrifying eyes, and into the deepest recesses of my memories, never leaving that spot. The soldier in their dark grey and newly-made-red uniform (gone) with their face uncovered and their eyes wide open (gone) descended like a fish with wings towards the bottom of the lake and the rest of the soldiers (coming closer) descended on me. They didn't kill me and I knew it didn't matter because my home (gone) and my mother (burning) were with me forever, for better or worse.

The artist picked up their black paint and drenched the entire canvas in it, leaving no brush strokes or hairs. I felt the floor underneath me (warm) bounce up and down as the painful sound of a large, strange metal animal rammed through my ears and into the deepest recesses of my memories, never leaving that spot. The entire day is lodged into the little crevice that I can't climb out of, the puny world that I'm still inside. The one path through the mountains and out of the valley was gone, about to be presented to me on the day of the black painting and the village (gone) that used to be my home (gone).

My mother (burning).

"She single-handedly killed General Anya, in one scratch!"

Get up.

I can't.

"Then she should be sent to beast island, or at least hanged for her crimes. Why have you brought her to me?"

There are two voices but many people. I can hear their feet and the slight murmur of their dark grey uniforms moving around on their thin cocoons of meat.

"If we train her with us, she could be an invaluable asset herself. You of all people should see the use in -"

The first voice, the higher, scared voice, stopped abruptly in its tracks. In its place was the sound of fear and breathlessness as the sea of dark grey uniforms gasped and murmured as they moved around on their thin cocoons of meat.

The second voice, the deeper, scary voice, took off.

"You have done nothing but cause me frustration, Force Captain," (each syllable of the last phrase stung, leaving holes in my ears every time I remember them) "You have been fortunate enough to hold your ground for this long but I have had enough of your disrespect. Anya was disciplined, smart, and rigid. She knew her place, and now she will never reach her true potential. If you really cared for the good of the Horde, you would have shot this little monster on the spot rather than drag her filthy body to my feet. I have had enough of your insolence."

The first voice, the higher, scared voice, fell and shook the warm floor, accompanied by the nauseating sound of bones breaking inside their thin cocoon of meat.

Get up.

The first voice did not get up.

The floor shook once more as the sea of dark grey uniforms erupted in murmurs and got quieter and quieter and then they were gone. And then there was me and the second voice, the deeper, scary voice, alone and silent.

Get up.

Get up.

The little bird in my knees stretched and stood upright, staring at me with its terrified, terrifying eyes. The floor wasn't shaking anymore but I felt it getting colder. The second voice was on its way over.

Get up.

Get up.

My thin cocoon of meat still had water left in it, pooling into the sea, drowning the little bird with wings that no longer worked. Instead, the fish grew wings and surged upwards, sending splashes of the black paint that blocked out the sun everywhere. My heart opened its mouth and yelled at me two words.

Get up.

The once-warm floor, reminiscent of the spring forest with its thick canopy of trees and vines that wrapped around my little crevice, turned to winter and the trees died around me and fell down like a fish with wings towards the bottom of the lake. My mother (burning) looked up and screamed two words.

Get up.

Get up.

Get up.

The chorus melted. My blood was screaming. My heart was screaming. The little bird, drowning at the bottom of the lake, was screaming. My mother (burning) was screaming. The sound of the water that blocked out the sun and turned my home (gone) black swelled in my aching eardrums as did the sound of the large, strange metal animal that was bouncing up and down on its way to the room with the two voices (gone). The floor was cold

enough to burn me and so I was burning (my mother). The screams wrapped around a blanket of sound from the water, the large, strange metal animal, the fire that took my home (gone), the first voice, the higher, scared voice, and the silence and then suddenly the executioner's axe that cut them all down.

I got up. My claws were ready to tear another hole in the canvas because I already had the whole day lodged into my little crevice that I could have escaped from and so nothing more could fit. My eyelids stood up and my terrified, terrifying eyes looked up to see the second voice, the deeper, scary voice, reel away from me. The ground was warm and my feet were bare. The woman in front of me wasn't going to kill me and I knew it didn't matter, because I was already dead by then.

So I ran. And she didn't chase me.

Drowned Little Birds and Flying Fish with Wings

Living in the Fright Zone was an odd experience at first. On one hand, all of the little birds that I saw were long dead, murdered before they could even think for themselves, but so was mine. But not hers. On the other hand, the soldiers with their dark grey uniforms and their terrified, terrifying eyes that killed my mother (burning) engulfed every blank, long hallway, tinted window, sullen bunk bed, teethed doorway, and nonexistent exit of this metal forest. A forest with no thick canopy of trees and vines to wrap around my little crevice but instead a looming threat of mountains, higher than the wave that threw black paint onto my home (gone) and now threw black paint across the entire world. I could hardly see the sky through the smoke and the metal and the lack of trees. But all the sky I needed was trapped inside of her, rippling across her own little freshwater lake in her stomach that was home (gone) to her fish with wings that flew away from me when I needed it most. Her little bird flew overhead, alive and well amongst a crowd of birds that lay to rest in acid and blood. Amongst my little bird, still, alert, and dead inside of me. She would talk to me in that third voice, the shrill, piercing, beautiful voice, and never let me fall back down into the same lake as the fish with wings that was over my town. I still thought about it though, as it never left that spot in the deepest recesses of my memory where it stays now. I don't often forget things but I rarely remember them in detail, unless they are painted and hung on my wall to observe at any time. She is a painting on my wall, with her kind, now coldhearted eyes that would always drive away the frigidity of the second voice, deeper, scary, that was incessant in my early life. The first voice was already a fading memory. Under the moons I would often tiptoe towards the earlier times when my mother (burning) was around. I would pour the ocean onto my feet and I would suddenly awake only to be more alone than where I was before. Unless I was with her. So I soon took to never leaving her side because I needed her. My bird was dead so she had to share hers with me, which was how we lived for

decades: sharing her life so I could keep mine, always under the constant guise of the second voice, deeper, scary, who wanted me dead from the very second I got up. But she wouldn’t kill me and I knew it wouldn’t matter because I was already gone by then, and I certainly am now (whenever that is). Adora knew that my wings had been chopped off, so her mother bird gifted me her child, a brand new little bird with wings, and tucked me under her downy wing. The downy wing that turned to a fly.

Then a gnat.

Then dust.

Then gone.

There were many days in the before-after-times but I remember few of them. I felt safe but not too safe, constantly under watch from the second, deeper, scarier voice (Shadow Weaver as I learned to address her). She would do terrible things to me and my newly born little bird with wings, but never Adora's. I would resent her for it but her kind, moon-eyes always made me guilty because of it. I still needed her, no matter how terribly different we became.

One of the before-after days I remember was one of the first days after the before-before-times. I had been stuck in the same place, too frozen to roam the new forest of metal trees and no creeks. Her mother bird's eyes looked deep into mine and gouged a hole through them, through the terrified and the terrifying. We walked for hours, for years, making sure no spot was left without being illuminated by the glowing specks of dust in our small, beautiful, moon-eyes. There were places prettier than others, metal tinged with an interesting light, metal bent and warped into people-shapes, metal sharp enough to cut somebody's throat, but no place more beautiful than my home (gone) or my mother (burning). On this particular day, we ventured farther than usual, towards a structure that my little bird with wings could not comprehend. As we barely scaled the ladder with rungs higher

than my body, the crevice all around me dissolved and sprinted straight down towards the bottom of the lake. I was, both figuratively and literally, on top of the world. One look down sent me spiraling into my own foresight, displaying every reality in which I ended up falling over the edge and down onto the hard metal ground of this strange forest. The bird in my stomach sunk down into my legs and I was standing there, not moving. That's the beauty of that highest spot, above all the clouds of smoke and fear and dead birds, if you move you fall off and if you fall off you die, your thin cocoon of meat strewn out randomly across the jagged corners and places prettier than others. I would know. Taking the scenes in, the many possible paintings scattered through my gallery, I felt an overwhelming urge to collapse. My thin legs withstood the force of this command, no doubt given by the little bird, but my chest did not and I began to capsize. However the lake I sprinted towards was not the same one as the flying fish that buried my home (gone) in water or the soldier (gone) that got too close or the first voice that I already had no memory of (gone), but the warm freshwater pond that was home to the bird mother and the fish with wings that lived. Adora caught me as I fell, no doubt saving me from my inevitable death that would come too soon after this day, in the after-after-times. As I laid there, coddled in her small skeleton atop a carcass of molten rocks and dead birds, limp and unmoving, I felt more comfortable than I had ever been at any other point in my life. My mother (burning) would be sad to see me go but I was ready to depart from her world and into the newer, puny world that Adora made bearable. And so I jumped in headfirst.

A figurine loomed overhead, balancing poorly on the mountain far up in the clouds of smoke and dead birds. It wiggled around on its axis and never quite seemed to decide why it was there in the first place. My eyes were fixated upon the strange, small-person-like shape that was too far away to notice if you weren't looking. It was this day, of all days, that I had braved the forest on my own, far away from the loving gaze of the mother bird and the fish with wings. It was the first time I had ventured onto land

since the land was swallowed up by the same water that took my home (gone) from me. On that day I waded through every land feature this city had to offer me, searching furiously for Adora, the only blue sky I had left. She was not in her bed, not at breakfast, not at training, nowhere. The blank, long hallways, tinted windows, sullen bunk beds, teethed doorways, and nonexistent exits of this metal forest began to shrink, each second drawing them closer than the last. The many eyes of the soldiers in their dark grey uniforms that usually weren't visible creaked as they turned towards me. All of them. I didn't belong here, I never had, and that was the moment that I realized it forever. Without my mother bird to hold me close or my fish with wings to lift me above the deep crevice, I was just the only living bird sitting atop a cemetery full of zombies. I could not stand the harsh illumination by the glowing specks of dust in their cold, cruel sun-eyes, constant and unbearable, so I did what I knew how to do and ran. Maybe she got sick of their eyes too and decided to run away, and if so I would follow her. She had made a promise to me when she gave me my living bird that currently sat in my eyes, letting the sea flow through them without any fish, and if she was gone then the promise was broken. I could not let that happen to us, I would never be able to forgive her or me for allowing such an occurrence, so I ran for her. I ran harder and faster than when the soldiers in their dark grey uniforms (closer) took my home (gone) and my mother (burning). I ran faster than when the second, deeper, scary voice was approaching me but would not kill me and I knew it wouldn't matter, faster than in any training activity this monstrous empire would make me complete. My life was truly on the line at this moment, and I knew that this time it would matter. The day Adora leaves me is the day I die and it matters. I scoured every spot of the new forest, all of the places that I had seen before and all of the places I hadn't. The dim light of the sun came and went, replaced by the coldhearted, kind eyes of the night sky and I kept looking. I devoured room after room, turning over tables and beds and lumps of strange substances just to see if Adora had wandered over and collapsed under the weight of all of the good she has had to do to keep me from dying. I could hardly see through the sea with no fish that was becoming

more empty the more I looked. And suddenly, the sun was up once again, and I still had not found my mother bird. I dropped to the ground, defeated by my own two legs, and stared straight up, and that's when I saw it. A figurine loomed overhead, balancing poorly on the mountain far up in the clouds of smoke and dead birds. As it grappled with reality, so did I, becoming the figurine myself. I was up on the highest point above this puny world, alone and scared, ready to leave the world of knowns and into one of unknowns. I suddenly knew exactly why the figurine was up there, why I was up there, and why it did what it did next.

When it first jumped I saw the flying fish over my home (gone) that filled my vision with black. I saw it recoil from the shot blasted through the center of its spine, shocked by the anticlimax of death that came far too early for things to be fine. The look on its face was a lock unpickable, but I already knew what it meant because I had had the same look for months. As it hit the bottom of the lake, it was stuck in a perpetual battle of trying to fight its way up. It thought about all of the friends' promises it was breaking after it left them, their family members that would never be able to forget this moment, their kingdom that needed a ruler but couldn't have one anymore, their last meal, their last book, their last intimate moment with their loved ones. It wanted nothing to do with the fate that revealed itself at the bottom of the valley underneath the mountain it fell off of. But that doesn't matter because they can't prevent it.

As it fell, I saw the face of my mother, who was no longer burning. It was a face of pain but a face that knew what was around the corner. While she was not keen on reaching her destination, she knew she could not reverse what had already happened so she didn't try. She lied there in the sky, barely moving, knowing that her daughter would always remember her and accepting the fact that she was just another small bird claimed by the terrifying nature of a war uncontrolled. By a military that thought it was doing the world a service. I saw her face and could see that she was not really there, but exploring every crevice in her brain to look for good memories. Her beautiful glowing specks flew about in flurries to bring back calm moments

where her family was still right up there with her. In the sky, barely moving. She smiled as she thought of them one last time, knowing all too well that none of them would survive the ongoing conflict. Grief comes in many forms, especially for mothers, and her version of mourning us was staying strong and accepting that it was over. We had had an amazing time on the planet together and she would not have changed a single thing. But if I had to change anything, I would have looked away. All I saw before was a mother on fire, racked with agony and slowly but surely turning black. I didn't see the neurons making beautiful constellations, but the embers and sparks choking on the sickly smoke that rose from her back, pointed straight up at the sky. I heard her voice make one last journey out into the air and die off earlier than her. No words, just an unforgettable sound. I see her now in her true form but it is too late because she was moving once again. I was going to lose her again.

The figurine got closer as the seconds dried and fell off their perches. I noticed a mask covering its face, the same mask that the second, deeper, scary voice used. The mask that covered up her terrified, terrifying eyes and the face that did not care what happened to anyone but herself. If she lost herself, she would have no tethers to keep bounded to the world that I reside in. No loved ones, no children, no family, no mother bird. I saw someone who had no choice, yet all of the agency anyone could hope for. She knew that whatever awaited her at the bottom of the valley, it could be no worse than the world above it that no longer contained her. I saw that her anger and abuse came from the absence of something, what that was I was not sure. Perhaps her parents were the same to her. Perhaps her parents also took to the sky too soon. Perhaps her friends broke their promises. Perhaps she never even had any to begin with. Perhaps she too was broken by the war, taken by the military that was not doing the world any service. Perhaps she joined them because she wanted to. Perhaps this was just the way things were and I was her victim because I was the way I was and she was too. I saw her think about none of this as she sprinted headfirst into the deepest recesses of my memories where she stayed forever.

Replaced with a blur, the figurine got closer to the ground than I thought it was going to make it before flying away. I saw my own face on the ground as I hurtled towards it, out of any control or reasoning. I thought about why I was here now, falling to my death, and how many reasons I could come up with. I was living while my mother was not. My mother bird had flown away somewhere that I could not find her and left me to rot alone. I hated them both for being so selfish but I hated myself for thinking that. I hated the people that surrounded me, the soldiers in their dark grey uniforms that thought they were doing the world a service by burning towns and homes and mothers. I thought about how much energy it required just to keep my head from sinking down into the same pit of acid my little bird was swimming in, still alive. What was about to happen to me was okay because anything else was one hundred times worse.

And so I watched as Adora hit the ground and shattered, staring at me one last time with her terrified, terrifying eyes.

Paradise (interlude)

Flung from my dream like a smooth stone across a lake, I felt the insurmountable sense of dread race across my blood vessels, shaking beads of sweat as it passed by. Looking back on the final sight I remembered, I felt the blood surging faster and I panicked. The hairs on my back stood on their tiptoes as my eyes adjusted to the darkness, filling the room with a shallow stream of light bouncing off of the moons outside. Moons like eyes. Beside me on the bed I could make out the shape of a mountain under the covers occupying a space I had assumed would be empty. The heavy black paint lifted more and I could see the mountains take the outline of a woman, *my* woman underneath the soft fabric of our shared cocoon. A cocoon that was not made of skin, muscles, and meat. I dared not blink as to keep the light in plain view. The darkness was home to the many animals that still slept inside of my stomach, itching for the opportunity to race upwards and lay their swathes of eggs in my rotten brain. It was still grey and bruised from all of the mold that had accumulated over the years, plastering the inside of my skull with a foul rot. But I could not clean it out because my hands were outside of my body. The only thing still pecking away at the filth was my little bird, the child of Adora's mother bird and her fish with wings that laid right next to me in our bed. A bed that was drenched in sweat and I could not rest in any longer. My legs kicked out to the right and dangled over the precariously high edge that dropped out onto our marble tiled floor. There were no carpets. Under my feet, the hardness and the coolness of the ground sent a shiver up my ankles and into my nervous system. This room was too cold and too big for just the two of us, or at least I thought so. Adora didn't seem to mind and she slept peacefully with no nightmares of metal forests or mothers burning or fish with wings shattering as they hit the ground in front of you.

I slipped silently out of the room and into the long, cavernous hallways that connected us to the world outside. *The only difference* , I thought to myself, *between this and the Fright Zone*

is that now I have more windows. And it was true, the windows were large and numerous all around the palace, feeding through them vast landscapes of forests with trees and rivers with water and birds that were alive and flying across the skies to escape the coming winter season. There was an immense difference between here and the Fright Zone when I looked outside, but I was here inside and not out there with the fish and the birds and the trees that populated the forest surrounding her home. The moons outside were staring at me with sad looks as if I had forgotten something and they knew what it was somehow, as if I didn't know myself. Behind them, the many stars still came as a shock to me. The only specks of dust I was used to seeing in the night sky were the ones that came to me in dreams and the ones that left me when I was still young, not these new ones that lit up what was supposed to be a cozy dark pool. They reminded me of times long past when I was among them, floating around in a puddle of my own stomach acid, just waiting for the woman I hated to come and fly me far away. But the day came and I was far away but I'm still right there among the stars. Floating. The more I looked out on the painting in front of me, the less I knew about it. *How many animals are there? How many stars are there? How many people live in those woods? How many homes are intact? How many mothers are not burning?* And so I sat there and let the ocean level rise as the salty, dirty water poured from me and out onto the pristine white marble floors of the palace. The floors that were cold.

When you live in paradise, the only things you can really think about are all of the small puzzle pieces that made up your life before it, and how much you miss them all. One puzzle piece was the warmth of the homes I had before. Homes that are burning or gone or full of metal. For every horror there is a beauty, and for every solution there is a problem. My problem is that I have everything I could ever want and can no longer complain if I am not satisfied. What excuse would I have for being unhappy? I have Adora, I have a family, I have a child. What part of them isn't enough?

As if on cue, Finn's crib erupted with noise, pulling me back to the room with the mountain on the bed that was now wide awake. The sound of an alarm clamored through my eardrums, bringing me back to those awful sirens in that awful metal city that I miss now more than I ever have. I held my child close to me as it continued to explode in my hand, reverberating endlessly off of the smooth, cold marble floors of the palace. They weren't even old enough to know how much their voice could hurt other people, but that awareness would come in time. Shivers racked my body and I noticed that I had not donned my coat yet, so the snapping autumn atmosphere stung as my short fur failed to keep it off of my skin. Adora must have noticed me slipping away, so she did what she always did, *what she does best* , and held me as close as I was holding her child. In that instant, we were all a little less alone. One entity, grasping itself in its warm hand as it shields off all of the terrors and beasts that lurk in the darkness of the cold hallways right outside. Our bodies and minds melted together as we shared our pain and started glowing brighter and brighter. The black paint was never-ending but so were we.

"Rough night?" Silence. Her question was less of an inquiry about my state of being and more of an observation. We had put Finn back to bed and were now more alone than before, wallowing in the cold, turbulent air outside of our balcony. My feet hung precariously over the large drop down to the river below, ready to join the fish at a moment's notice. She held back, standing as far away from the railing as she could with a coat wrapped tightly around her exposed skin. As her question rolled off me with the wind, flying off into the valley, I sunk into the attempt of posing one back at her. I could try and say something funny, making her laugh always made me feel better, but that isn't the easiest thing to do if you're on the verge of tears. The blanket wrapped around my body was far too large for just me, the empty space forming the same starless night I was both craving and deeply afraid of. Without moving my head or saying a word, I lifted up my arm and begged her to fill that space. Without any instance of hesitation, she leaped forward and slowly slid in next to me bringing her warmth with her and taming the rising drum that echoed across

my chest. I was scared in this moment, not knowing particularly way, but I knew that I was alive and with the one woman I needed to have in my life. My mother bird.

"Are you okay, Catra?"

No.

A Foul Aftertaste

The Bright Moon Palace is a labyrinth of all the things that I hate. Long hallways, tall doors, cold marble floors, pearly white walls, and opulence fit for a queen. When the daylight came it reflected off of the perfect polish on every surface and gave off an unnatural glow. This light, however, did nothing to warm up the air in the colder seasons and so autumn and winter were spent huddled around fireplaces and in heavy blankets. Not once did I complain about my new accommodations but they all knew I despised it. Often times I would find myself wandering from room to room, usually trying to find someone or something, and cursing the day I failed to burn the place to the ground. The Gardens were all so meticulously cleaned and kept that they stopped resembling nature and sank back into the beautiful facade that they were immersed in. I could never bring myself to visit them for that reason, as the sense of uneasiness followed every time I did. Every lamp and chandelier shone brighter than the sun, washing the nighttime away while they were turned on. In every sense of the word, this home was fake.

Today is alright, I thought to myself every once in a while, this particular time being when I took Finn into the town of Elberon for the yearly Festival of Flowers. They of course begged me (and the royal guard reluctantly obliged) to bring the Queen's Daughter along with us to join in on the festivities. The two children were incredibly close friends when they were younger. Looking at them running from stand to stand at the festival, playing off of each other's energy, reminded me of how I used to act with Adora when we were just tiny birds flapping around in that horrible cage. These birds were free to fly high into the sky, further to the sun that I ever was. I watched as Finn plucked eagerly at their bundle of deep red cotton candy larger than my head, disregarding how bad it was. Their teeth would be a mess after it all. The Queen's Daughter held her own lump of candy, however hers was a surprisingly dark shade of black. As I watched the lack of color calmly ooze down and pool at her feet, I began to wonder

whether it was candy at all. I rubbed my eyes, blinked, and it was purple. Finn stole a large chunk off of her candy and she started chasing them, trying to grab it back. There was no malice in such a heinous action, no matter how blatant the act of theft was. The two birds were smiling from ear to ear, their bright moon-eyes sending off pulses loud enough to make anyone observing them start to smile. But I was not smiling. I stood steadfast and emotionless as my thoughts were elsewhere, as my body was elsewhere, and the children did not notice. They didn't see the hunched over figure of a woman painted pink through the crowds of party-goers and flowers, but I did. The sounds of excited children and bored parents walked off, replaced with the flowing creek nearby. A shadow swept over the town, puppeteered by a large cloud that stood in the way of the sun. The woman's head turned to face mine and she was smiling, as if she understood something that I didn't but was willing to share it to me. I didn't want to know. I wanted to run to her, to yell at her, to claw her face off, but I stayed my ground instead. She kept smiling at me, some of her teeth missing or rotten, and her eyes dug tunnels through my stubborn knees. Knees that were stubborn by choice, not by inability. In an instant, the sun returned, the crowd reemerged from the water, and the woman disappeared, replaced by two smiling children with sugar covering their mouths.

"Mama Catra!" one of them said, their mouth full of candy "Tha suga is reeeeely good! Haf you had some?"

"I haf not!" I replied enthusiastically, knowing that I didn't want any but would have to taste it anyways. The Queen's Daughter handed me her large purple lump, barely any of which was eaten off of, and I grabbed myself a piece. It felt impossibly soft in my hand, as if I could squeeze the life out of it without the slightest of efforts. I lifted it up to my lips like it was nothing but air and held it there for a fraction of a second's worth of hesitation. I didn't often have sugar. That's what he fed me when I was floating with the stars. The cloud I grasped in my fingers was not what he fed me, though. It was familiar to me, even if it was terrible for my teeth. As it passed through my lips, I felt nothing but a slight tickle. The food barely even existed outside of how it

looked. Finally, it hit my tongue. It was sweet at first, but a foul aftertaste soon replaced it, as if the sugar was poisoned. I never liked sweet foods anyways.

"May we play in the water, Finn's Mom?" said another child. I looked over at the creek to see a solemn flow of freshwater. The late summer was when the river was only half of its normal size, as the mountains that fed it were already frozen over. I told them to go to the river, but to take off their socks and shoes first. There were many other children playing there, so I assumed they could find someone else to entertain them that wasn't poor old Finn's Mom. "Thank you!" she said before running off again with Finn following close behind, as if tethered to her by a cable. *Thank you*, I thought to myself. What an interesting phrase, one I never really knew growing up. We were always expected to fit the training quotas and perfect standards as cadets, given no gratitude if we succeeded, and punished if we failed. Shadow Weaver was mostly the worst of it, but her bitterness seeped into others and became cold neglect. No one was fine with how things were, so everyone had to pretend like people who defied it were weaker than them. Maybe that was why I sat still as a stone on the hill overlooking the creek, the foul aftertaste of sugary candy marinating in the saliva around my tongue. I gulped down hard to try and remove it but it stayed there as still as me. The kids were soaked already, not having been in the creek for more than thirty seconds. The bright white of their clothing was a dark grey now, infused with the same liquid that drowned my home so many years ago. But I could not dwell on that, not for my sake, but for theirs. The bird in my stomach may have died and been replaced, but I would make sure to nurture theirs as best I could to make sure the same thing didn't happen twice. No child should have to pay the price for crimes their parents were victims of.

The story of how the Queen's Daughter died is one I don't know. I was not there and no one told me what happened. All I know is that one day it snowed and then one day she was gone. Twelve years of age, unexpectedly tall, deep brown skin, deep brown eyes, so on and so forth. These were all things I knew about her, but I knew nothing about what kind of person she was, what kind

of bird she contained, what sky she floated around in when no one else was watching, who she loved and how much she loved them. I spent little time with her and it was always with Finn too, as she was their only friend. She had always stayed close to her parents, never quite as adventurous as my child, and would be very polite when they were not around. She ate with perfectly small bites during the holiday feasts, she would wear shoes and jewelry that matched with whatever pants or shirt or dress she had on. She, or her parents, cared deeply about how she was presented to other people and always left a good mark. I know she was musical because her mother would often brag to me about how angelic her voice was when it seeped through the thin shower walls. I never heard her sing and she never sang to others, but everyone knew sang by the quiet humming she often thought was unnoticeable to others' ears. Finn told me she once sang them a song she wrote, that it was beautiful, and that I could never tell anyone that they told me. I smiled to them and imitated a zipper across my lips, keeping them closed on the subject forever. Her eyes were a pearly grey, although their true color was elusive. When you looked at them, different wavelengths would reflect at different angles, creating a ghostly mirage of vibrancy where there was none. I only saw them briefly but they were memorable. They seemed distant, like mine, as if constantly staring at paintings that were prettier than the reality thrown in front of her. When I thought of her after she died, I saw a child who did not belong in this world because I had to. If I saw a child that really did exist, that would have meant I saw a child that should not have died. In reality, she was a kid who liked sugar candy and pastel green and music. She was the child of my two best friends in the world and either one of them would easily lay down their own life to replace her death. She was impartial to the issues that plagued our world, starving many and slaughtering many more. She was not fit for the world beyond our own. She did not deserve to die.

The palace was silent that winter. If one were to wander into it, unfamiliar to who lived there or how significant it was, they would assume it was deserted. The garden plants all turned brown only

to be covered in white weeks later. It was not in our place to say anything about the elephant in the room, so Adora and I would never address it. Our joint dinners and hikes happened less and less until we barely even knew we lived with each other. The palace was big enough that we could all walk to where we needed to go without bumping into one another. The windows were the same color as the walls now all but the forest turning entirely white, the off-green of the trees just barely visible. Long past was the time when I facilitated the destruction of the area's fragile environment, one that ignored the seasons altogether. The first winter we had was a disaster, as many inhabitants of the forest starved or moved away. The great kingdom of Bright Moon stooped, lower then than ever before. And many years later, with the Queen practically no longer in her own body, things only got worse. The winter of silence was the last winter I witnessed at Bright Moon.

There was one moment that was bearable in those three excruciating months. I remember the fireplace as bright as if it was burning the jelly in my eyes into liquid. And whenever I do remember it, my molten eyeballs run uncontrollably down my face. The three of us, Adora, Finn, and I, gathered around the warmth atop the fluffiest carpet we could find. Adora had found an old artisan chess board, a game my mother taught me (and the First Ones invented), that was given to the Queen's mother long before any of us were even born. The mother I killed. We sat for a while, arguing over which rules were real or what the figurine of the horse was named, before trying to teach it to our child. In a matter of a couple hours, they beat their Mama Adora in a display that left her face red and her eyes wide open. She couldn't accuse them of cheating since we had only just taught them the game, and it was practically impossible for anyone to cheat at it. Often times, instead of moving, they would stare at a piece's intricate craftsmanship for an indefinite amount of time, the details transfixing the gaze of such a curious youngling. We would often have to remind them that the game was still ongoing to get the play started again. That day I still stayed undefeated, as I never forget anything my mother taught me, but I'm sure

they could beat me now. In one especially long game between me and them, Adora could not be bothered to stay and watch such a boring activity so she laid her head on my outstretched leg and fell asleep. Her chest rose and sank, mimicking the lake that still resides in her stomach, the little bird and fish with wings swimming happily. Her face, usually haunted by tension while she dreamed of terrible memories, was at rest alongside her limbs. Here eyelids were not pressed down, her forehead was smooth and flawless, and no little noises escaped her except for slow, deep breaths. Finn started to laugh but held it in, knowing very well that Mama Adora needed her well-deserved rest. We kept playing. Eventually all our pawns died off leaving a neverending dance between our kings and the piece neither of us could agree on the name of. One of us moved, the other adjusted. After a few minutes it became less about who would make the better move and more about who would fall asleep first. And that's why I've never lost a game of chess to Finn. As the young bird tucked in its head, sinking below the warm pool of stomach acid, I felt the pleading cacophony of screams that was exhaustion, stabbing at my legs and my eyelids to try and make me collapse like the other two. I was done running from the calm embrace of sleep by then, as I had won at chess once again. I had no reason to stay awake. In that instant, we were all a little less alone. One entity, grasping itself in its warm hand as it shields off all of the terrors and beasts that lurk in the darkness of the cold hallways and forests right outside. Our bodies and minds melted together as we all laid down to sleep on the same carpet, under the same blanket, by the same fire. Adora's head rested on my leg and our child was close beside us. The snow piled up on the other side of the window, but it would have instantly turned to steam had it approached the most loving family remaining in all of Bright Moon.

This Puny World

When Finn was around four years old, still barely familiar with how to talk, they asked me a question that I was not ready to hear. People don't usually expect children to be particularly damaging, but their innocence and lack of awareness works both ways. There are a few people that just do not get other people's emotions or, even worse, intentionally drive stakes into them to break them. While that is the case, there is not a single child in this world that could know about any of that. Finn, with their glowing moon-eyes, looked at me with such a cute smile, oblivious to the fire falling around them, and asked me how Mama Catra and Mama Adora knew each other before having a child. Such a simple question has no clean answer, and they know that now. At the time, though, they really could not have predicted how complicated and full of pain our stories were. I tried searching for an answer for a while, but upon looking back at my moon's eager face I could bear the thought no longer.

I have had my fair share of violent outbursts over the years, spanning a wide assortment of victims. Looking back on all of the pain I have reflected is something I do more often than Adora thinks I should, especially given that many of them had either forgiven me or died. But I could never forget them, especially the versions of them preserved by the trauma I gave them. But the moment I painted my moon with the same black brush as all the others, I knew that I had to fix myself. Adora and I talked extensively on the events of that day, thinking of ways I could be helped or tamed or fixed. I did not hurt Finn, but they were clearly terrified of me. In all honesty I'm not sure what I did, ironically, since that moment is one of the few things I don't remember about myself. They always were careful with their words around me, even if they loved me, because after that day I could tell they loved me a little bit less.

To have your own child stare holes into your skull is enough to drive any sane person insane. Luckily for me, I was already insane to begin with so I mostly just sat with it and soaked in the shame.

Even in moments when they were calm or happy, I would look over and see those blood moons, the eyes of someone who fears for their own safety. I would see them in doorknobs, in water glasses, in mirrors, in the night sky. The giant pool that spread out above our heads was forever tainted by those eyes, something I still see now. Adora was kind to me after it happened but I knew she loved me a little less too. She trusted me with her child and I betrayed that. I broke yet another promise, once again sending me back into various nightmares and visions of the past. For a while I would hang in a balance of reality and dreams, never quite knowing what was imaginary and what was concrete. The royal health staff tried all sorts of tricks on me, odd plants, odd crystals, odd music, but it all fell down to the bottom of the lake that filled me up inside, my little bird swimming across the surface gleefully. The lake was filled with so many items that managed to fall down into it, but it was deep enough that a lifetime's horrors could not fill it to the surface. The music and the crystals and the plants slashed against the surface, but knives are useless against the water. It's this lake that made the winters so much worse than they would usually be. The famine, freezing, and colorlessness of the world around Bright Moon walled in what was once a perfect view out of the window, now a foreign planet, and immersed me into the stars where I floated so long ago. All of the pressure from the whiteness of the snow, the whiteness of the hallways, the whiteness of the lamps and chandeliers, practically killed me. That's why I never made it to my twentieth winter at Bright Moon.

I talked to the queen a few weeks before it all changed, all of our friends were over for a giant holiday feast, as we both had had enough of the party and left to sit under the glass roof of the covered gardens. It was remodeled to stay alive during the winter season, so it was the only splash of green in the white world. She seemed a bit on edge when I first caught a glimpse of her, but she was staring at a flower as if to try and calm herself down. Perhaps she was lost in her own lake too. I went over to her, said hi, and sat on the floor next to her. It was over a minute before she spoke back to me.

"Do you ever think that Finn is growing up too fast?"

I asked her what she meant, although I knew far too well the feeling she was describing.

"Aislin is usually so nice to us, but recently she's been acting..."

I looked her in the eyes, catching her reluctance, and saw what she meant by how her eyes shook in their sockets. I reassured her that it was just a teenager thing, and that Finn was a tough wrap sometimes when they were mad at us or obsessed with something or feeling frustrated at the world. It was just a part of aging that we missed by living in a time of bloodshed.

"How do you guys do it? You and Adora seem so ready for this- this whole parenting thing," she wiped her eye with her ornate sleeve. "Bow is trying to be the nice guy but sometimes she is just so hard to reach. She's out so late, even when we tell her to come home for dinner, even when it's snowing. I hate that feeling of helplessness, like, I'm her *mother!* That should mean something, right?"

As she turned to me for approval, I could feel no words in my throat that would work in a situation like this. I'm terrible at calming people down. Instead, I just wrapped my arms around her and hugged as tightly as I could, hoping her demons would be expelled by the force. Her tears made my skin stand up as they bounced off my back, but I did not let go for another while. When we pulled ourselves apart, she was still on edge but she seemed more comfortable. I contemplated inviting her back inside, but I was not too keen on returning myself. So I told her a story.

Finn was around eight, maybe nine, and was getting super obsessed with trees. I mean like, naming each type of leaf, each different species and their properties, all of that sort of stuff. I think they were spending a lot of time with the gardener or something. He's pretty cool so I can't blame them. Anyways, they would always go on hikes with us and try to pull me and Adora into these super dense foresty places but we always told them 'no, we have to stay on the path, come on Finn' but that only made them more interested. I got him a book for his birthday, oh

yeah so he was nine, that was just *full* of different trees and plants and fungi and gunk or whatever. Perfuma recommended me a great author, I think he was from her village a while back or something, but he really knew his stuff. This book was absolutely gigantic, but Finn insisted on reading the whole thing. Adora and I would always laugh about it and await the day that they jumped onto another obsession. So this all comes back to one night, I think you remember it sort of.

"I do" she said to me through a small chuckle, right in the middle of my train of thought.

Well, fast forward to a few weeks later and it turns out they're allergic to certain plants, especially this one fern that grows in the east part of the woods. Back to that one night, they go out with your daughter and just run through the woods collecting all different plants to put in boxes or something, and they come home at two in the morning, covered in dirt and leaves. Adora and I were so pissed at them, because I woke up in the middle of the night to find Finn gone. He even pulled the whole pillows-under-the-blanket bit to try and trick us.

"Aislin has done that to us more than once now. It doesn't even look remotely convincing!"

I stopped to regain my memory, then continued. I told her how Finn came home sneezing and coughing, their throat halfway closed up. We thought we were going to lose them, but it wasn't really that serious. The doctors gave them the right medicine and they were back to normal again, but the same thing happened again only a few days later. We found them in their room, hacking up a noise unbearable to any mother's ears, surrounded by a wide variety of leaves from different plants arranged in neat lines in order from smallest to largest. After that incident, they looked directly at me and spoke words I would never forget:

"I don't really like plants anymore Mama Catra." And that was that.

The Queen's eyes, dry once again, were fixated on me as I told my end of a story she knew only half of.

"You know, Adora told me that whole thing but it sounds so much funnier when you tell it instead."

So much for her knowing only half of the story. We looked up to the sky to see that the moons had barely budged an inch during the whole conversation. Time works in silly ways sometimes. Either your child's childhood tiptoes past you before you even catch a glimpse or you talk for hours and everything around you freezes in place.

The Queen was, expectedly, the one that was most affected by the loss. It was her daughter after all. I only ever saw her once during the aftermath, but her face is one I had seen before. Although I usually hated the gardens at Bright Moon, the workers had mostly left for their families or moved away entirely, so the indoor oasis stayed unkempt for many months. On a particularly sunny day, the light made my head pound too hard whenever I was in the stark white rooms and halls. The garden was the only place I could truly sit with myself and not be burdened by the unstoppable rays that bounced around without end off these impeccably built walls. As I made my way into the greenery, my eyes half closed, I came to see why people seemed to like it so much. It was the only place in the palace where nothing felt curated, because it wasn't. I did not come from wealth or power, in fact my first home was built around the center of a tree stump, and so everything else in this massive complex was unfamiliar. Even the windows, paintings of landscapes and night skies, were otherworldly to my undeveloped mind. I was an ant that crawled onto the surface of a great reflective pool and I saw myself for the very first time. Ants are not supposed to see themselves. The garden draped a towel over the mirror, giving tired eyes a time to relax and forget about whatever was bothering them. The benches were simple and not filled with pink pretty cushions or soft down. I was transfixed by this newfound appreciation of beauty that took me decades to attain, so much so that the time

fell down past my head and made a sharp noise as it went. Woken out of my daze by this sound, I flinched and looked up. The moons were out, the torches were lit, and the garden was glowing with the exotic bioluminescent flowers that the Queen held at such high esteem.

"They're so pretty!" I remember her saying the first time we found them in the far regions of beast island. Entrapta explained to us how the toxic chemicals that leaked out of the wasted electronic equipment killed almost all plant life that existed prior to its takeover. Whatever substance was used at the time to cool and clean these things was dangerous to everything else. However, some plants survived and developed an immunity to the chemicals, a few of them even incorporating them into their own systems. These flowers that the Queen loved so much grew in such small numbers and required a certain, poisonous substance to water and grow. But the glowed in the dark, so here I was, sat in a field of deadly flowers. It was for this reason that Finn and the Queen's Daughter were never allowed into the garden, let alone even told where to find it.

As I stared intently at the strange plants, thinking about their origin and how close I was to becoming one of the unlucky organisms killed by the toxicity, another strange noise reached my ears with the force of a tidal wave. The faint trickle of water had briefly transformed into a small splash, quiet enough that a fish could have made it. There were no fish in the Bright Moon gardens. Hairs all over my body stood up straight as my claws outstretched. I felt my breathing steadily speed up and my eyes widened to where I could see almost everything around me. But the faint glow of the flowers could not illuminate all the room, and the pond at the edge of the fake forest was covered in a sheet of black ink. The stream of water, pumped through the room artificially, was drowned out by the terrible silence of anticipation. My blood vessels widened and my heart prepared to sprint out of my chest and onto the moss that covered the heated forest floor. Again I heard the noise, now clearly coming from the corner of the room, and it was much louder than before. The low light lit up small ripples in the pool, emanating from one source that I still

could not quite make out. I saw movement, something larger than a fish, through the blackness and into a dark gray. The slight splashing turned into a thicker sludge, growing louder than I had hoped it would. I sat there on the bench, still as a boulder, hoping it was all in my head. I had not blinked in many seconds but if I did I would miss whatever was in front of me. The figure submerged entirely and began swimming towards the perfectly straight shoreline. the ripples in the water heightened and grew much closer. The glow of the flowers illuminated something directly below the water they hung over. Out popped its hair, its forehead, its eyes, its nose, its mouth, and nothing more. Slowly, approaching the light, I saw the face of nightmares, the look of a demon standing across the room from your bed as you struggle to gain control over your own body that you're trapped in. Its eyes did not change shape or emotion, locking their view directly into mine, sending a clear sign of distress streaking across my nervous system. I was afraid, but so was it. As water rolled down the Queen's face, I could not tell whether they were freshwater from the pond or her own tears.

Mothers are never supposed to experience the pain of losing their child, the living, breathing thing that they have devoted their entire essence to sculpting. When the Queen lost her daughter, she lost herself along with her. I saw the same person in her then as when she encountered me, broken and defeated under the weight of my own mistakes, and threatened to take my life. She had grown so much and put in so much work into the people and things around her since then. Her childish nature had transformed into beauty and maturity, her previous recklessness had honed her into a brilliant strategist, and her love for her friends redirected into love for her poor daughter. She never stopped working and putting in effort to better the world around her, but the world had given her absolutely nothing in return. I had killed her mother, the winter had killed her kingdom, and now the universe repaid her by killing her daughter. The Queen had nothing else to live for. These painful memories always take me the most effort to recall and retell, but they are important to me in that they all taught me something. By seeing someone even more racked with

inconclusiveness than I was, I realized that I needed to change my own ways. Without those eyes, the eyes that had no one behind them to come home to, I would have never been scared into changing the look on my own.

The moons are gigantic. Each one of them could come crashing down on our planet and kill us all, but they stay far away in their perfect little orbits. If one were to wobble in its path, it could become a great extinction event, wiping our people and our sorrows far into oblivion. That, or it could fly out into space, becoming a giant weapon for the next unlucky planet. But the moons themselves are small. The suns and stars around which they fly could easily swallow them up, and if the stray too close they could get sucked in. The moons stay close to our planet because they are scared of dying, but by looming over such small people, they too can become scared of the moons. The moons are terrified, terrifying eyes that see across the entirety of our puny little world, far above all of the insignificant issues that are invisible to those without eyes or brains.

For this, is why I knew exactly what the Queen was doing in that pond, and for that is why I never returned to Bright Moon again.

Loved Ones and Lost Lungs

Get up.

It's time.

My eyelids slid out of the way as I became conscious again, surrounded by nothing except for the dim light of the eyes that looked down from above my room. The Mountain slept soundly beside me, moving with barely noticeable increments, knowing nothing of the minutes to come. My bare feet slid onto the carpet without making a sound, the bed underneath me still damp with my sweat. I was nervous, but nothing I could do would be able to contain the feeling so I embraced it. My heart slid out of my chest, falling gently onto the pillow where my head rested next to hers, the woman that gave me life, that saved my life, that was my life. But by now I had long since been dead, her beauty meaning nothing to me. My stomach slid down into my knees, carrying the bird along with it, still swimming happily in its deep lake filled with all of the terrible things that I had dropped in there. It would look down and see monsters far larger and scarier than itself, but they did not matter because they did not have wings and could not fly away. My body slid out of the room, past Finn's quarters, past the long hallways, tall doors, cold marble floors, pearly white walls, and the windows that were large and numerous all around the palace, feeding through them images of budding trees, thawing ice sheets, and fish swimming around furiously in the depths of the cold water. I slid outside the building, my coat on my back, my pockets full of coins, my bag full of food, and my head full of nothing, and started down the many flights of stairs. The eyes were now directly above my head, boring holes down through my spine and into my feet. The cold slid across my fur, making it stand up, alert, awake, alive, and alone. It was going to get warmer, but I would have to tough out

the end of winter before the spring could wash over the puny world. My legs slid past one another, easing my body into a full out sprint across the palace grounds and towards the dock. The wind was pushing on my back as if urging me to run away faster, but the frigidity was almost enough to stop me in my tracks. The boat slid off of the pier, the rope that once bound it unraveled at my feet. I felt nature arguing with itself, trying to decide whether I should be forced to stay forever or forced to never return. My loved ones slid out of view as the Bright Moon Palace became a fly, then a gnat then dust, then gone. The only part of it that remained visible was the faint glow of the flowers in the garden, where I knew they accompanied the frail figure of the Queen, a mother who lost their only child.

Get up, I said to myself, one last time.

I hate water. While, of course, I need it to survive, it is also the main ingredient for one of the most painstakingly desolate places I have ever been in my life: the ocean. Cruising through the rivers on my small paddleboat was bad enough with the rough currents and constant dampness of my fur, but once I got out onto the open seas it all became worse. Immediately struck with regret, I contemplated returning back home to say I was out on a long walk for a day, but as my indecision turned hours tenfold, I knew I could not turn back. To keep myself company I brought along a diary, one which I did not ever write in. Instead, the only words that occupied its many pages were *Too Mama Catra from Finn! I love you and hope you have the best berthday ever!*

As soon as I opened the book I closed it again and threw it into the sea. I could not be forced to read the rest of the ghostly message if my life depended on it.

After ten days of sitting alone at sea, a nearby ship saw me and turned course to come pick me up. Piloting it was an unfamiliar, but comfortably friendly looking captain who wore a coat adorned

with ribbons of many colors. "Lieutenant Jen Earl of the Salineas Navy" he called himself, which I thought was an odd name but I was really not in a position myself to be able to judge. Onboard with him were various barrels of a foul-smelling substance, I didn't ask what it was, and one caged lizard. Earl told me about the current poor conditions of the naval fleet, something to do with fighting an organized group of pirates, but I was far too racked with dehydration to really give the story any mind. The boat looked modern, without sails, but I neither saw nor heard an engine onboard. Everything was so quiet there that I could practically forget I was surrounded by water on all sides for miles. The large barrels that smelled terrible often clinked around when they hit each other, reminding me that we were on a moving ship, as if to keep me in reality as I spent the next week or so belowdecks. My cot was hard, similar to my old accommodations from my time in the metal forest, bringing over me a feeling that terrified me but comforted me at the same time. When I was not eating or thinking, I found it incredibly hard to stay awake on this rocking crib, slowly lulling me into a cold trance of sleep.

Alert. Awake. Alive. The sound of birds overhead, real ones, drew me out of the cave and back on my feet. I lurched forward, the lizard next to me turning its head slowly to see what the commotion was. The smell outside, minus the odd barrels, was different than it was before. The lizard stared judgmentally, as if knowing everything about what I was doing in those days. As I stared back, as if competing, I tried to pry out what it was doing here but I could come to no conclusions. I never asked Earl about it, so I was left wondering for the rest of my life. Stretching out my sore muscles, I hobbled my way up the cramped staircase to the deck, where I could see the faint outlines of a coastline straight ahead. My days in the desert would soon come to an end, to my great relief. Far below us, down in the deepest recesses of the ocean floor, sat a giant sea monster. When I looked over the side of the boat I could see its outline as it snaked across its vast terrain, occasionally sending bubbles of air up to meet me at the surface. The long snake seemed uninterested, or unaware, of our presence in its daytime sky. If it knew we were there, it had no

problem with us. I had first noticed the shape of it the day before, a sight that sent me into a fit of panic while Earl attempted to calm me down and explain to me why we weren't in danger. To this day, no diver has ever reached the monster, or if they had they did not have enough air to reach the surface alive.

Lieutenant Jen Earl of the Salineas Navy was the best possible company onboard the beginning of my journey. He asked me no questions of where I had come from, of why I was in a boat alone in the middle of the ocean, nothing. He spoke little of himself and his past because he could tell I would not listen or remember it. Instead, he brought out cards to play with or books to read. His cooking was delicious, better than the chefs back in Bright Moon, as I could tell it was coming from a personal place instead of a paid job from the royal family. We did not get to know each other, but I would recognize him anywhere, even though we have not spoken in years. The way he spoke of the different types of fish, the most difficult birds to shoot down, the ones you were not supposed to shoot down, and everything in between made each of these normally boring topics vastly more interesting than anything I had ever heard before it. He articulated every word with a different emotion, his voice's incredible range dropping down to a low and then bouncing way back high as if he had been a soprano in disguise. His humor brought a little light to the murkiness that I currently was sat in, unmoving, but comfortable. He did not own a chess board, but he was fun nevertheless. When we reached land in a faraway city that I did not know the name of, he gave me back my bag, filled with fresh food, smiled at me, and wished me good luck. We didn't shake hands, we didn't embrace, we didn't fake conversation about seeing each other again. We knew we would never see each other again. I smiled at him and walked off down the pier towards the city that I would not stay in. My path lay further inland still.

I later found that the city of Phobos, as various street signs had writ, was not far from the Palace where one of the Queen's good friends resided. I had seen her a few times but never really talked to her much, as I think she never truly forgave me for the

methodical deconstruction of her home city back in the war. As I walked through the small paths in the dense, wet rainforest, I would occasionally catch glimpses back out to the ocean. One of these glimpses was that of the new Capital, a grand spire jutting out of the ocean, that was home to a kingdom I wanted no business with. At the sight of the massive port (probably home to Jen Earl), I promptly turned around and walked back the way I came. The hilly and uneven terrain was not easy to navigate but it was better than the blinding white halls I was used to. Here, in nature, nothing was straight or angled or curated, it was perfect. Nothing about this thicket was similar to the woods back where I was. The plants were different, the colors were different, the water was different, and the sound was one I had never even imagined before this. The sloped ground beneath me breathed deeply every couple of minutes, the wind it produced shaking the trees with an amazingly loud rattle. Every step I took I felt as if they could come undone and topple over on top of me, but they were steady as the creature at the bottom of the ocean. The further I walked from it, the higher the terrain became, and the less I was able to keep up my pace. With every breath the earth took, my lungs shrunk a little bit smaller. The bird inside me was hungry.

I ran out of food at the perfect time. Winter down south in Salineas was short, the coldest temperatures rarely dropping low enough to kill of the wildlife. By the time my bag was empty, my fur was caked with mud and bug bites, my clothes were torn, and my lungs were gone, the sweetberry plants were in full bloom. I reluctantly took a taste of them when I first saw them, desperate to survive my journey through the trees, and expected them to be poisonous. Days later, my bag was stained red with the juice of them, filling every container I had to the brim. My water was still an issue but I was able to live off the berries alone, walking for many hours a day, sleeping when I was tired, for a time I can not be certain of. All sense of day and night, years or seconds, children or adults, is lost within those leaves and vines. Once I had been on my way for some time, though, my mind gave way to imagining the worst. *What if I never make it out of this forest?*

What if the berries are secretly making me hallucinate? What if I'm already dead and this is hell? Eventually, the threats that I had made up for myself became more dangerous than the actual perils of traveling through a jungle. My feet stopped caring about the mud, my hands stopped caring about swatting the bugs away, and my eyes stopped caring about scanning the forest ahead of me. My head was no longer with my body, instead floating once again among the stars in a night sky that I could not see through the foliage. It would be a lie to say I had never felt so closed in, but it certainly was far from enjoyable. I stopped counting days only a few days in, and that was many days ago, again I found myself at the mercy of my own warped perception of time. And then the noises began. The terrible, terrified, terrifying noises that echoed off of every tree around me, masking their origin. It sounded unlike any animal I was familiar with, real or metal, and could not have possibly come from an Etherian like myself. This sound was special. While it came from a million voices, it sounded like one thing was making it, one collective brain that controlled every plant, every root, every bead of water in each living thing in the forest. It really was hell. That was when I began to run for my life. Each footstep I took multiplied into many, bouncing endlessly off of the unbeaten ground, thick with ferns and strange fungi. None of the flowers glowed, so I had no idea where I was going or which direction I was even facing. All I knew was that I was going up, and that up was good. Up meant I was ascending higher above the puny world below. The bird in my stomach stretched its wings and, like instinct, shot into the sky like a bullet fired from a strange metal animal. The sound, only screaming louder, hurt the inside of my skull. It was so painful that I could not even notice the numerous scratches I was collecting from branches and thorns and trees that I stumbled into. I was moving too slow with my unwilling muscles, but it was better than not moving at all. A strange glow emerged from far in front of me, swelling with the sound that was now powerful enough to break my stride. Every tendon in my legs seemed to snap at once as the wall of noise hit me like a tidal wave, screeching through my eardrums and making my eyes water. As I fell forward, I felt the heat of a thousand fireplaces at once, no longer cozy, breathe

itself across my scarred face. The trees around me were falling now, falling for real, and I found out exactly what the noise was.

As I rolled head over tail across the forest floor, I heard confused shouting coming from right over my head. I could not care less what they were saying, whether or not they were saying it to me, because when I sprung to my feet they didn't seem to notice. What I saw briefly was a long line of dark grey figures, large metal tanks attached to their backs, holding out metal poles in front of them. The trees all around me were burning or on the ground, growling louder than the animals that were about to burn alive. One figure, brighter and higher than the others, raised its arm up high to the sky and I caught a glimpse of the reflection of the stars on its eyes. Two beady, large, perfect holes cut out of glass right into the strange suit that covered up its entire body. Its arm shot down to the ground as it yelled something terrifying, not knowing that I was directly in front of the smaller figures with metal tanks. I hit the ground with all the force I could muster, letting my own exhaustion do most of the work. Above my head, the sky erupted in an orange glow and my ears popped and then began to toll, the bells far away and high pitched. The sky became black again, the forest did not, and I screamed as loud as I could to try and drown out the noise that I could no longer hear. It was all too loud. With my last bit of strength gone, I slumped back down and closed my eyes, underneath the night sky full of stars and eyes and now a volcano.

The Masquerade (interlude)

The masquerade was starting and her face was all but there,

The sky above erupting in a race to rip and tear,

The feeble bones and evil thoughts were breaking down and eating up,

The woman sitting underneath the surface of a prayer,

The shallow waves were looming far above the sunken sky,

The eyes that lurk the gloomy stars blow up as they collide,

The paintings fade, they're thrown away to places they could not escape,

The memories they made would stay and watch and never die,

The figures cast with metal limbs let down their heavy tanks,

The fire cast which blazed the forest flooded fearful banks,

The taller one lays down his gun 'cause she was laying down for once,

The very essence of her past was leaking down her face,

A careful hand descended on the not-yet-murdered corpse,

A breath flew out her lungs and brought on coughs that burst her doors,

A sickly view voraciously evolving over patient leaps,

A timeless act that kept her beating heart for hours more,

A cry emerged from vocal chords surviving hellish scapes,

A cytoplasm burned and hoped to force the cell to break,

A bloodstream filled with toxic ash and gases far to dense to ask,

A living soul to breathe them in and not collapse with weight,

A photograph too adamant to die was still intact,

A hopeless after-after thought was spry enough to act,

A wounded creature bound by either chains or metal snakes would see,

A final chance to live again by putting on a mask,

Get up.

Footstep

The familiar feeling of being flung from a false world flew past me as the sky stopped erupting and the bed underneath me replaced the soft grass from the night before. I felt around in the darkness, throwing off the covers with my aching arm, barely mustering up enough strength to do so. I expected to be greeted by the warm glow of the daylight, but although I heard the sounds of morning insects and animals in the distance, the nighttime sagged over my room like a bubble waiting to burst. I carefully spun my body around, sitting up in the stiff cot, now not such a comforting feeling. Pins and needles on my back urged me to lean forward, the skin running down it creaking as I did so. Scanning around the room, my eyes were not adjusting to the darkness, so I went to go get up and find the door, or at least a lantern, but as soon as my legs straightened, the cuts that bore their way into them screamed out in unison under the weight of my own body. The ground rammed into my burning scars, exciting the fiery feeling that I remembered from my dream. The world around me erupted once again and I could no nothing on the freezing floor except scream with all of my might. The fleeting feeling of self control was only a whisper in my ear, everything else roaring like waves as the pain washed over me. I heard a door to the left of me burst open, the wall behind it making a dull, dampened thud. Two people were talking frantically in a language I could not understand, their footsteps only heartbeats that I felt through the floor. One of them dragged my torso back up, propping me against something and grabbing something out of a bag that clinked and clicked as it moved about. A glass was pressed against my lips, one that I did not have the willpower to refuse. As the cold liquid seeped down into my stomach, the bird that once swam there made no comment. It was long gone, far beyond those cliffs I had never climbed myself. *Good for you.*

Days passed, unbeknownst to me at the time, and my wounds recovered with them. As people came in and out of the room, they talked to me more and more, slowly starting to teach me

their language. There was one thing that they didn't teach me, however, because I learned it in my own time. The nighttime was never going away, as long as I lived. The stars and eyes above me would not return to the sky and neither would the sun. For a while I could barely come to terms with such a reality, but I eventually took it in stride, too tired to fight fate itself. One child that visited my room a lot brought in a chess board and we spent a few hours making up a system of noises, above the concept of a language altogether, that would allow us to play. If chess could work without my eyes, I had nothing to be afraid of. My broken leg was taken out of its cast after some time, and I was allowed to get up and stand in my room instead of being wheeled around in a chair or carried by doctors. This strange town welcomed me with open arms, somehow believing that I had saved them from being burnt to the ground. I heard that they had put up railings around the place I was staying so I would not fall. The food I was given surpassed anything I had ever eaten before this, and took me down into a time far before everything changed. Far before I was even aware that I was in the before-before times. As my urges and anxieties settled down with the passing seasons, I became more comfortable with talking to those around me. Their tongue was odd, using many noises I was still just learning how to create, that sounded like the odd coos of a baby who was not yet comfortable with talking to those around them. I could still sometimes see my bird, circling the mountain ranges and soaring over the lake, but it never once rested on the water like I was used to. *What are you doing?*

One of the townspeople, the child that played chess with me, visited me often to talk about everything they could think of. I felt quite silly playing the role of the wise old woman, but the people explained that I was older than everyone there. Most of them would die of disease or hunting or fighting with whoever was trying to come for their land at the time. Their smithery burned hot, I could feel that with ease, so I knew they were tough, but even people who managed to keep out the Horde had limits. They paid for their safety in the lives of those who protected it, who I learned were numbered in the tens of thousands. There were

other towns in their small forest nation filled to the brim with similar stories. Even so, I felt their energy radiate from their bodies, moving always with a bounce instead of a drag, talking in high pitches instead of low drones. The child, who's name I do not remember, told me that they had a belief in their culture, that by being happy, the things that were truly sad would appear, instead of simply the illusions of sadness that our brains create. I didn't understand this, as the illusions my brain made for me were far too powerful to simply smile away, but I respected their efforts. I lost a game of chess to the child, so it wasn't like I could win an argument.

The railings that were installed became less useful as I memorized the distances between my destinations, be them my house, the dining hall, or the pond. There was a pond, a real one, that was always teeming with wildlife. They put down a bench to let me sit there, where I would sometimes stay for hours unbothered before someone came to talk to me or I got up to go back to sleep. Life was slow, relaxed, and utterly boring. Nothing changed from week to week, no new stories were told, no new games were played, no new noises appeared at the pond. I would tell the children about my past over and over until the words I spoke lost their meaning. According to them, it had been a year since I first appeared engulfed in flame, but it felt like a lifetime had flown by just like the bird that had escaped my stomach. Sitting on a raft, stuck in the middle of that lake, the bird finally came down to perch. It sat on the wooden structure in front of me, staring at me with its terrified, terrifying eyes. *What do you want?*

I felt the cold touch of someone's hand on my shoulder, shooting me out of my slumber. I knew it was nighttime by the lack of putrid smells and blistering heat. I sat up and asked who it was disturbing me so late at night, but the hand did not move, nor did it answer my question. It slid beside me in bed, making not a single sound, but I felt its warmth beside my body. Its hands slid past my chest, wrapping around me and locking into each other, holding me close. I did not resist, for some reason, but I was still not sure who would be doing this. I asked it again who it was, but this time it responded.

"I love you."

I bounded from my spot, my head slamming against the ceiling sending me tumbling onto the floor below. I reached for the woman that was next to me but she was gone, leaving no footsteps as she escaped my house. I knew that I could not have left her behind for long, that she would catch up to me, but I did not know how little time I had. I laid down on my small, floating raft and thought to myself for a while. The bird was sleeping on top of my stomach, bobbing up and down as I breathed in and out. Birds sleep standing up, giving the uncanny feeling that you are being watched even if you are not. The bird was most definitely not watching me, but I knew it saw my every move. I wondered whether I should have just climbed back into bed and forgotten about it all, but forgetting was not my style. I knew that if I lived with this memory, I would not be able to live a life worth living in the long run. This could not be what became of the girl who never got caught, the one who kept on running and never stopped. The one who killed the first soldier to try and lay hands on her and the girl who almost killed the entire world. I could not curl up in a ball and wither away in a town nobody had heard of, while my life before waited outside of the door, waiting to scare me as soon as I stepped out. The bird perked up, now wide awake, and tilted its head as it stared into my eyes. *Okay, little bird, I will listen.*

The forest was easier to leave than I thought it would be, its dense web of smells and sounds now less terrifying without my plight of vision. I had stolen a mask made by one of the children, the one that had beaten me at chess, who was studying the art of woodworking. I could hear each one of my breaths circle around it and wedge past my face as they escaped into the night just like me. The trees slowly gave way to a quieter meadow with taller grass and less things to avoid tripping on. My walking stick, a large branch I picked up off the ground, moved easily through the terrain and urged me into a faster pace. I felt the ground spin backwards as I stood in place and let it take me wherever it wanted. The grass turned to dirt and the dirt turned into sand. As I entered what I could only assume was a desert, I took off,

sprinting faster than I ever had before, not leaving a single footstep in the sand as I made my way out of the lake, over the mountains, and far away from the puny world behind me. I watched myself grow smaller, turning from a bird into a fly.

Then a gnat.

Then dust.

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